LEADING BY EXAMPLE



With road widening for the 2028 Simhastha Kumbh Mela running into trouble in Ujjain—attempted demolitions at the city's main Shahi Masjid had led to clashes—Madhya Pradesh CM **Mohan Yadav** found an unusual way to make a case for the public project. He brought down structures at his own ancestral home, 2.9 sq. metres of which fell in the project's path. Yadav admitted the moment was emotional, but said Ujjain had to be ready for an expected 400 million pilgrims. The symbolism travelled faster than any state notice. By September 28, the mosque committee itself removed the affected portion. Sometimes, a personal example is the most persuasive bulldozer of all.

FAMILIAR FARCE



The Congress has somehow managed to pick a fight with itself in the one Gujarat district where it has an MP. Banaskantha chief **Gulabsinh Rajput** waited nearly nine months for approval of a district team before losing patience and announcing his own list on social media. Three days later, state president Amit Chavda junked it, saying it lacked approval and that the district organisation was anyway being bifurcated. Rajput has since promised "full disclosure" about colleagues, while the district Youth Congress chief has resigned amid local anger over the treatment of Rajput and MP Geniben Thakor. It seems the Grand Old Party just can't stop tripping over itself.

ICONIC FAUX PAS



West Bengal higher education minister **Jagannath Chattopadhyay** has managed to give the legendary Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar an achievement even the late 19th century reformer might have struggled to claim. Speaking at a public event, Chattopadhyay credited Vidyasagar with establishing Sanskrit College and championing education through Bengali. Just one snag: the college was founded in 1824, when Vidyasagar was just four years old. He did become its principal in 1851, but then was more known for championing English and western philosophy, and challenging orthodox methods of learning.

Kaushik Deka *with* Avishek G. Dastidar, Ashish Misra, Rahul Noronha, Jumana Shah *and* Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

ECO WATCH

SUPER EL NINO
KILLER HEAT AHEAD

By **Jumana Shah**

The El Nino building up in the Pacific is on course to become the strongest ever measured. A new study estimates it will cause about 451,000 additional heatwave deaths worldwide. India is particularly vulnerable, for it could claim up to 15,800 extra lives by February 2027, and could get worse thereafter.

Sea surface temperatures in the Nino 3.4, the benchmark zone for tracking El Nino in the central equatorial Pacific Ocean region, was 3 degrees above normal in mid-September, according to Columbia University's International Research Institute. The Climate Impact Lab (CIL), an initiative of the University of Chicago's Energy Policy Institute, says this could push global land temperatures about 1.2 degrees above normal in the coming months, bringing about 44 per cent more extremely hot days than in a normal year.

CIL projects 451,000 excess heat deaths between June 2026, when the El Nino began, and February 2027, compared with the 1996-2025 average. Of these, 239,000 may fall between September and February. The Global South will bear the brunt.

India's death doom projections aside, the larger concern lies beyond the forecast window, which does not yet include the pre-monsoon months when most heat deaths take place in South Asia. The CIL report anticipates that India and Pakistan "will see heat-related deaths continue to rise into their summer".



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

There is also the possibility of ocean link disturbances via the Bay of Bengal. The factsheet names past instances of severe cyclonic storms—including Remal (2024) and Mocha (2023) that hit India—as evidence of extreme weather disturbances induced by rising ocean temperatures. Together, they affected thousands of lives and caused hundreds of deaths in the country.